instacart

Case Study

Instacart Agent Readiness — Product

Six scenarios, one thesis · Product-lead response · September 2026



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THE THESIS

Agents won't fail at Instacart because they can't read a catalog. They fail at the moments a person used to decide quietly — **which oat milk** when the first is gone, whether **"2" means bags or kilos**, whether the **5th order this month was really wanted**. So: find those moments, make each decision **machine-readable**, and let autonomy grow **only as fast as the evidence** does.

Q1 Why groceries first

The one big category where the job **repeats weekly**, the **rules are already on file**, and a mistake costs a **line-item refund**.

▲ Cohorts: 2.1 → 3.9 orders/mo · 3 saved replacement modes · #1 category shoppers would let AI buy (28%)

Q2 Flashy board demo?

Build — but not the throwaway. Stage the demo on the real substitution contract; theatre capped at **5 engineer-days**.

▲ OpenAI retired in-chat Instant Checkout ~6 months after launch; Walmart saw ⅓ the conversion

Q3 Checkout or substitution API

Substitution. Checkout is a permissions problem the industry is standardising; substitution is a **judgment call on a live clock**.

▲ Public MCP: 2 tools, none for replacements · ACP / UCP+AP2 / card tokens already cover payment

Q4 "quantity: 2" read two ways

A **contract bug, not an agent bug.** Typed measure + expected-total checksum + **read-back** of what we understood.

▲ Instacart itself deprecated bare quantity/unit for line_item_measurements (18 Mar 2026)

Q5 Orders per user per month

4 autonomous orders/month, ≤1 per rolling 7 days; the 5th needs one tap. Raise caps only on evidence.

▲ Loyal cohorts average 3.9/mo · 300 clean orders ⇒ unintended rate <1% at 95% confidence

Q6 "Should we be worried?"

Yes — enough to act, not to stop. Name the failure modes, sign three tripwires, keep an assumptions log.

▲ Gartner: >40% of agentic projects cancelled by 2027 · Instacart's own $60M FTC consent case

90.3M	orders in Q2 '26 (+9% YoY)	$115	average order value	1.6B	lifetime orders	2B+	catalog items · 2,200 retailers	3	agent platforms: ChatGPT · Claude · Gemini	Sep 9	Clementine, Instacart's own agent, launched

Context figures: Instacart Q2 2026 results [5]; Clementine launch coverage [4]; ChatGPT/Claude/Gemini integrations [1][2][3]. Full source list on slide 8.

Q1

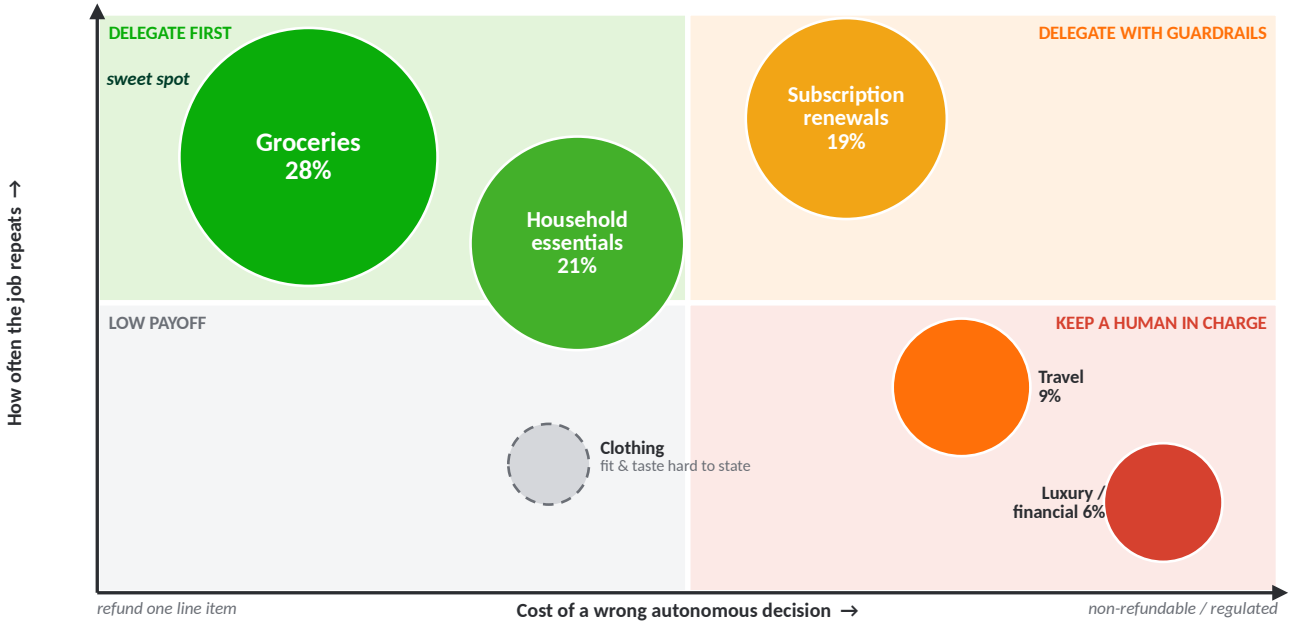
Why groceries are a good place to start

The question: Make the case for why groceries are a good place to start.

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Groceries are the one big category where the job repeats every week, the customer's rules are already written down, and a wrong call costs a line-item refund, not a lost holiday.

Delegation-fit matrix: where should autonomy start?



Bubble area ∝ % of US adults comfortable letting AI buy in that category [17]; grey = no survey value. Placement on the axes is the author's judgment. ACI finds the same order: groceries 41% vs household 31% [18].

FRAMEWORK **4R delegation screen: Repeat · Rulebook · Reversible · Record**

REPEAT

3.9×
orders / month

Instacart's monthly orderers go from **2.1 orders/mo in year 1 to 3.9 by year 6** (2017–22 cohorts) [7]. US shoppers make **1.6 grocery trips a week** [23]. Clementine already takes "**order my usuals**" [4]: the recurring basket is a natural job to hand over.

RULEBOOK

3
modes on file

Per item, customers already choose **up to 3 named backups / best match / refund**. Approved replacements are **saved for future orders**, with tags like same brand, similar price, gluten-free [10]. The agent inherits an existing personal-shopper brief. It doesn't invent one.

REVERSIBLE

95%
satisfied w/ a replacement

Orders containing a replacement score **95% satisfaction**; replacements per order are at their **lowest since 2022** [6]. A wrong item is a line-item refund, not a non-refundable fare. The downside is bounded and already priced in.

RECORD

1.6B
lifetime orders

2B+ catalog items, **2,200 retailers**, 10M+ daily stock signals [4]. Order quality is already measured: perfect-order fill rate improved **16 quarters in a row** [5]. Agent orders can be judged against the **human baseline from day one**.

WHY GROCERY IS HARD — AND WHY THAT IS THE POINT

About **two-thirds of Instacart orders contain meat or produce** [5] and stock moves constantly (**10M+ inventory signals a day** across ~100k stores [4]). The agent's value is not typing a list; it is **handling the stockout the way you would**. That makes grocery a real test of judgment, not just automation, and it is why Q3 picks substitution.

Wedge: "Refill my usual basket within my rules." **Wedge metric:** % of recurring baskets delivered with **zero edits and zero issues**.

WHY NOW

Gemini now **operates Android apps itself** on Pixel 10 / Galaxy S26 (Mar '26) [24]. The Ninth Circuit (Aug '26) held a **user-directed agent's access is the user's access** [16]. The phone's agent is coming either way; better it uses a front door than scrapes the UI.

HONEST COUNTERWEIGHT

Only **22% of GenAI shoppers trust agents to decide purchases** [19]. So launch is **opt-in, recurring-basket only**, drafts before autonomy (Q5). Frequency alone isn't the case; frequency **plus** a written rulebook **plus** a cheap undo is.

[4] Clementine launch, Sep 2026 · [5] Instacart Q2 2026 results · [6] Q2 2026 earnings call · [7] Maplebear S-1 / Q3 2023 call · [10] Instacart Help Center: replacements · [16] Ninth Circuit, Amazon v. Perplexity · [17] Supermarket News · [18] ACI Worldwide via Retail Dive · [19] FoodNavigator, Sep 2026 · [23] FMI Trends 2026 · [24] 9to5Google

Q2

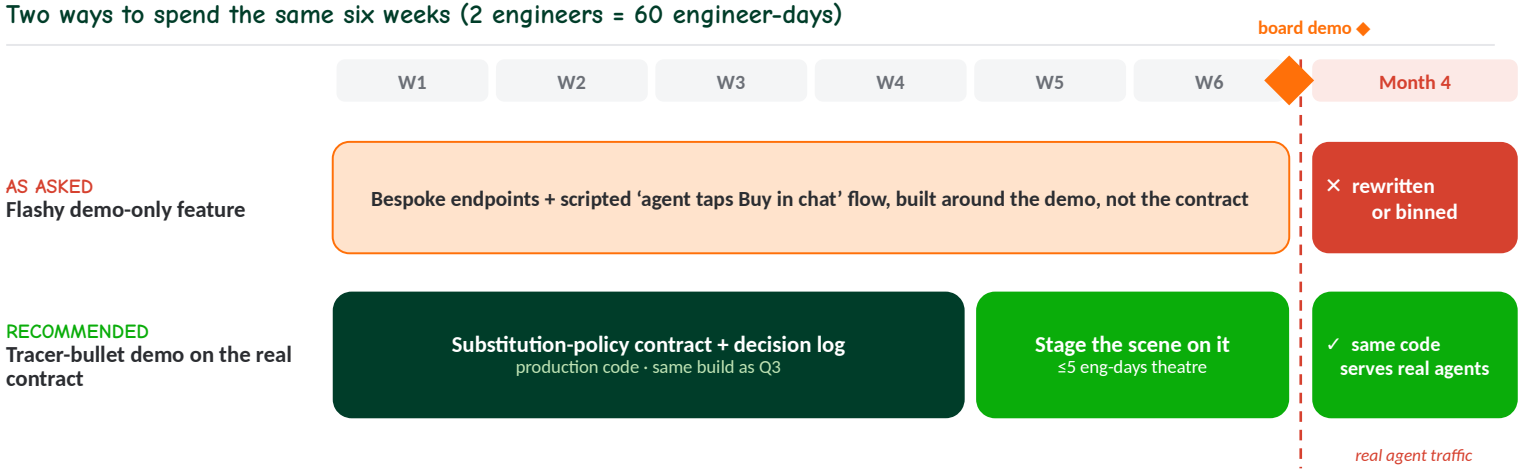
The six-week board demo

The question: Product team wants a flashier feature for a board demo in 6 weeks that you believe will be thrown out in 3 months once real agent traffic hits. Build or push back and delay?

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Neither as asked, nor a delay: I build a board demo on the real substitution contract, so what the board sees in week 6 is still running in month 4. Scripted theatre is capped at 5 engineer-days.

Two ways to spend the same six weeks (2 engineers = 60 engineer-days)



The salvage test: every demo component goes in one bin before it is built

KEEP · production contract

~48 eng-days · 80%

- Substitution-policy API (read/write)
- Decision log: saw → rule → chose
- Timeout rule + refund fallback
- MCP tools for agents
- Sandbox stockout scenarios

WRAP · scripted, calling real contract

~7 eng-days · 12%

- Stockout event injected into inventory feed
- Demo household + recurring basket
- Presenter UI over real API responses
- Board-facing decision-line view

THROW · pure theatre

≤5 eng-days · 8% (hard cap)

- Stage animation & narration
- Hard-coded 'wow' timing
- Slide labelling what is scripted
- Anything that forks a production schema → refused

On stage: the stockout save (everything real except the scripted stock-out)



MY ANSWER

I build, but a different thing. I won't spend six weeks on a feature I expect to bin in three months, and I won't make the board wait. They get a demo that is still running in month four.

FRAMEWORK **One-way vs two-way doors + tracer bullet**

- **Two-way doors** (UI, narration, staging, demo data): build fast, time-boxed, disposable.
- **One-way doors** (production API contract, data model, public MCP schema): **no change for the demo's sake**. This is the only line I push back on.
- **Tracer bullet:** a thin but **real** end-to-end path the team keeps extending, not a mock that has to be rebuilt.

Evidence: the flashiest step isn't the durable one

- **OpenAI Instant Checkout**: Instacart was first to ship it (Dec '25) [1]. OpenAI **retired it in Mar '26**, ~6 months after launch; checkout moved back to merchants [12].
- **Walmart:** in-chat purchases converted at **⅓ the rate** of click-out; called it "unsatisfying" [11]. The flashiest step in agent commerce had the shortest life.
- **Gartner:** >40% of agentic-AI projects will be **cancelled by 2027** (cost, unclear value, weak risk controls) [13].

HOW I SAY IT — AND IF THEY STILL INSIST

"Let's give the board something still standing in month four. Name the moment you want on stage; I'll build it on the real contract and label what's scripted — boards remember being told."

Still insisting? They sign the salvage test; I log my dissent in the assumptions log (disagree & commit). I escalate to the sponsor **only if it forks a production contract**.

[1] Instacart × ChatGPT launch, Dec 2025 · [11] Search Engine Land: Walmart ChatGPT checkout converted 3× worse, Mar 2026 · [12] CNBC: OpenAI revamps shopping after Instant Checkout, Mar 2026 · [13] Gartner, Jun 2025. Effort split and 5-day cap are proposals to negotiate, not findings.

Q3

Checkout API or substitution-preference API?

The question: You have 2 engineers and 4 weeks. Make the checkout API agent-readable, or the substitution-preference API agent-readable. Which one?

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Substitution. Checkout is a permissions problem the market is already standardising. Substitution is a judgment call on a live clock that only Instacart's data can answer, and today an agent can't read it at all.

Theory of Constraints: where does an agent-run order actually get stuck?

BOTTLENECK

1 Build cart	2 Checkout	3 In-store shopping	4 Delivery
LOW	DETERMINISTIC	HIGHEST	MEDIUM
UPC match, saved lists [8]; no clock	slot + payment; handoff works today [2][3]	live stock × partial prefs; shopper waiting in aisle	refund path + issue metric exist [5]

Weighted scoring (1–5; weights and scores are the author's judgment)

Criterion	Weight	Checkout	Substitution
Agent-specific uncertainty (judgment needed)	25%	2	5
Real-time clock (a person is waiting)	20%	1	5
Gap left by industry rails (ACP · UCP/AP2 · card tokens)	15%	1	5
Moat: needs Instacart's own data (1.6B orders)	15%	2	5
Cost of shipping it late	15%	2	4
Fits 2 engineers × 4 weeks (no PCI / fraud review)	10%	3	4
Weighted total (out of 5)		1.8	4.8 ✓

WEEK-1 DRAFT · substitution_policy object (one per recurring-basket item; built from the 3 modes Instacart already has)

```
{ "item": "upc:0001111041600",  "mode": "specific_backups",      // | best_match | refund
  "backups": ["upc:…", "upc:…", "upc:…"],                      // ≤3, ranked, as in today's UI
  "constraints": { "max_price_delta_pct": 10, "same_brand": false, "dietary_must_match": ["dairy_free"] },
  "on_no_response_s": 300,  "fallback": "refund",  "set_by": "agent:phone-assistant",  "consent_ref": "c_82f"
}
```

MY ANSWER

Substitution-preference API. An unreadable decision can't be patched later: by then the agent has already improvised in the aisle.

Why not checkout (yet)

- Rails exist: **ACP** (OpenAI+Stripe), **UCP + AP2** signed mandates (Google), **Visa Intelligent Commerce / Mastercard Agent Pay** tokens with spend caps [21][22].
- The market moved checkout **back to the merchant**: Instant Checkout retired [12]; Claude & Gemini carts **hand off to Instacart** to pay [2][3]. Today the gap costs one tap.
- Real checkout work means payments, fraud and chargeback review: not a 2-engineer, 4-week job anyway.

Why substitution

- The public MCP server exposes **only create-recipe and create-shopping-list** [9]: no way to read or set a replacement rule.
- In the aisle a person answers the shopper's ping. **An agent can't, unless the rule is written down.**
- Instacart already has the rulebook [10] and a new **dietary-aware replacement model** [6]. Expose it; don't rebuild it.

The 4 weeks, and what "done" means

W1	Audit what exists; spec the policy object + delegation limits
W2	Read/write API + MCP tools get_/set_replacement_policy
W3	Decision log with reason codes; timeout → policy, else refund
W4	Sandbox: all backups out · +40% price · allergen · 2 agents conflict · mid-shop edit · agent silent

Done = every recurring-basket item has a readable policy, every replacement maps to a logged reason, all 6 scenarios pass.
Would change my mind: if the phone agent has no scoped way to hand off or pay at all, checkout goes first.

[2] Claude integration, Apr 2026 · [3] Gemini integration, May 2026 · [5] Q2 2026 results · [6] Q2 2026 call · [8] Developer Platform docs · [9] Instacart MCP docs · [10] Help Center: replacements · [12] CNBC, Mar 2026 · [21] Google Developers: UCP/AP2 · [22] PYMNTS: Visa & Mastercard agent tokens

Q4

"quantity: 2": one field, two carts

The question: Two agent platforms read "quantity: 2" on the new Instacart API/MCP differently: one orders 2 units, one 2 × 1 kg packs of wheat. Where is the problem, and how do you fix it?

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It's a contract bug, not an agent bug. A bare integer plus a server that silently picks a unit lets "2" mean two things. Make the meaning impossible to omit, check it against what the user expects, and say back what we understood.

Root-cause map (fishbone → 5 layers where "2" can lose its meaning)

Agent A → 2 units (whatever pack the resolver picks)

SAME PAYLOAD

```
{ "name": "wheat flour",
"quantity": 2 }
```

Agent B → 2 × 1 kg packs = 2 kg

Layer	What goes wrong	Likelihood	Evidence
1 API / MCP contract	Bare integer, unit optional: "2" carries no kind (each · pack · weight · volume).	HIGHEST	Instacart deprecated LineItem quantity + unit, 18 Mar 2026 [8]
2 Server resolver	Given several measurements, the server silently picks the "best" one; the agent never sees which.	HIGH	Same changelog: "Instacart can choose the best one" [8]
3 Catalog modelling	"Wheat flour 1 kg" may be a pack, loose weight or multipack; sold-by differs by retailer.	HIGH	2B+ items across 2,200 retailers [4]
4 Tool description	Tool text/examples never say what quantity counts; each platform's prompt fills the gap.	MEDIUM	Public tools: create-recipe, create-shopping-list [9]
5 Agent parsing	"Two bags of atta" → JSON differs by model; least controllable, so never rely on it.	MEDIUM	Inference; unsourced

✕ BEFORE · ambiguous

```
{
  "name": "wheat flour",
  "quantity": 2
}


// 2 what? each? pack?
// kg? server guesses
```

✓ AFTER · typed request (oneOf by kind)

```
{ "product": {"upc": "8901725…"},
  "measure": {
    "kind": "pack", "count": 2,
    "pack_size": {"value":1,"unit":"kg"}},
  "expect_total": {"value":2,"unit":"kg"},
  "on_mismatch": "reject" }
```

↩ READ-BACK · structured response

```
{ "resolved": "2 × Atta 1 kg (pack)",
  "total": {"value":2.0,"unit":"kg"},
  "identity": "exact_upc",
  "checksum": "MATCH",
  "status": "OK" }
// shown to user + audit log
```

MY ANSWER

Fix the contract so no agent can send "2" without saying 2 of what, and make the platform repeat back what it understood.

Hour one: 5 Whys, starting with a diff

Replay both requests from the logs. Are the payloads identical?

- YES → server-side: resolver / catalog (layers 2–3)
- NO → upstream: tool text / agent parsing (layers 4–5)

FRAMEWORK **Poka-yoke: make the error impossible**

1. **Typed measure**: kind ∈ {each, pack, weight, volume} as a oneOf discriminated union; MCP 2026-07-28 allows oneOf/$ref in input schemas [20]. **No bare quantity on the agent path.**
2. **Identity by UPC**, not by name: Instacart already prioritises UPC when supplied [8].
3. **Expected-total checksum**: the resolved total must equal expect_total, or reject.
4. **Read-back** in structuredContent + outputSchema, as in aviation.
5. **Still ambiguous? Ask, don't guess**: MCP elicitation sends the user a typed form [20].

KEEP IT FIXED

Golden corpus of ~100 real listings (multipacks, loose produce, dual-unit) run by **every** integrated platform in CI; a failure blocks release. **Metrics:** read-back mismatch rate; "wrong quantity" support tag.

Migration: ship the typed schema alongside v1; the agent path rejects bare quantity after a 90-day window announced in the changelog.

[4] Clementine launch (catalog scale) · [8] Instacart Developer Platform changelog, 18 Mar 2026 & create-shopping-list docs · [9] Instacart MCP docs · [20] MCP specification 2026-07-28 (tools, elicitation). Corpus size and deprecation window are proposals.

Q5

How many autonomous orders per user per month?

The question: Agent orders raise volume but risk "I didn't mean to place that order" complaints, with no history for agent-initiated purchases. What threshold of orders per user per month, and why?

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Start at 4 autonomous orders per user per month, with no more than 1 in any rolling 7 days; the 5th asks for one tap. It covers a loyal weekly routine, so hitting it is a signal, and caps rise only when evidence says so.

4 autonomous orders / user / month (launch cap)

≤ 1 per rolling 7 days · 5th+ order ships after one tap · spend ≤ user's cap · opt-in only · cap on autonomy, not on orders

Progressive-trust ladder: each user (and cohort) climbs only on evidence

R0 DRAFT

Agent builds the basket; **you press Place.** You see: "Your usual basket is ready: 23 items, $118."

Learn: edit rate
Gate ↑ opt-in + 4 drafts with <10% of lines edited

R1 SEND + HOLD

Agent places; **60-min cancel window** before shopping starts. You see: "Placed. Tap to stop before 4:10 pm."

Learn: cancel rate
Gate ↑ cohort: 300 orders, 0 "didn't mean to" ⇒ <1% @95%

R2 AUTONOMOUS

4/mo, ≤1 per 7 days, inside spend cap + substitution policy (Q3). You see: a receipt with every decision explained.

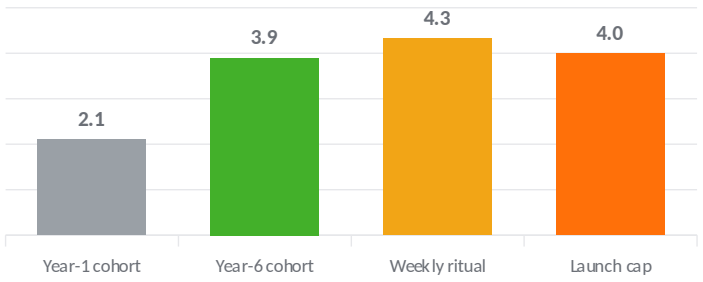
Learn: issue ratio vs human
Gate ↑ 90 days at or below human issue baseline

R3 PERSONAL CAP

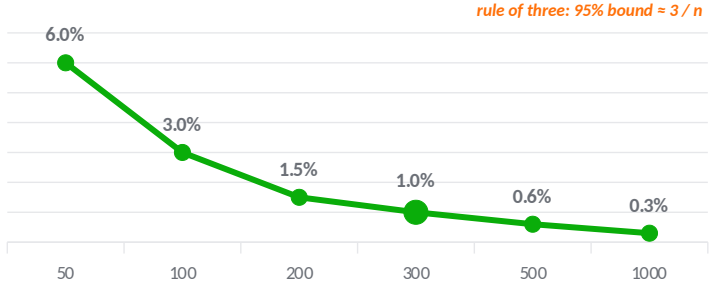
Cap = **your own P90 cadence + 1** (hard max 8); you can raise it yourself. Heavy households aren't throttled by an average.

Learn: long-run trust
Tripwires can send anyone back to R0

Where 4 comes from: orders per month [7]



No history? Bound it: max unintended-order rate (%) after n clean orders



Why 4, not 5, and not 10

- **It covers the routine.** Instacart's most loyal cohorts average **3.9 orders/mo**; year-1 users **2.1** [7]. A normal user rarely hits 4, so hitting it is a **signal**.
- **The 5th-week tap is a feature.** Five-slot months come ~4× a year, which gives a periodic **explicit re-consent**. That is the standard the FTC's Dec '25 order now holds Instacart to for recurring charges [14].
- **It caps autonomy, not orders.** Order #5 still ships after one tap, so ≈0 GTV is lost; friction lands only where risk concentrates.
- **The cost is asymmetric.** One unwanted order ≈ **$115** [5] of mostly perishables refunded or wasted, plus a trust hit. One extra tap costs ≈2 seconds.
- **The 7-day rule does the real safety work.** A monthly cap alone lets a runaway loop place 4 orders in an afternoon; the rolling week stops it at #2.
- **Not 5:** a weekly user would never meet a re-consent. **Not 10:** that's 2.5× the most loyal cohort, so a 10th unreviewed order is likelier a loop than a need.

FRAMEWORK Guardrail stack: every check must pass

Spend	≤ user cap (default ≈1.25× your median basket)
Novelty	never-bought-before item → one tap
Substitution	only inside the Q3 policy object
Rails	cap enforced twice: Instacart + payment token (Mastercard Agent Pay supports monthly caps [22])

TRIPWIRES (PROPOSED, SIGNED IN WEEK 2)

- "Didn't mean to order" tags **>0.5%** of agent orders (30-day) → cohort back to R0
- Cancel-in-hold **>5%** or issue ratio **worse than human baseline** → freeze promotions
- Add a **"didn't mean to order this"** reason code so the complaint becomes a counted metric

[5] Instacart Q2 2026 results ($115 AOV) · [7] Maplebear S-1 / Q3 2023 call (cohort frequency, 2017–22 cohorts) · [14] FTC v. Instacart settlement, Dec 2025 · [22] PYMNTS: Visa & Mastercard agent tokens. All thresholds are launch values to tune; the 3/n bound is the standard 'rule of three' for zero observed events.

Q6

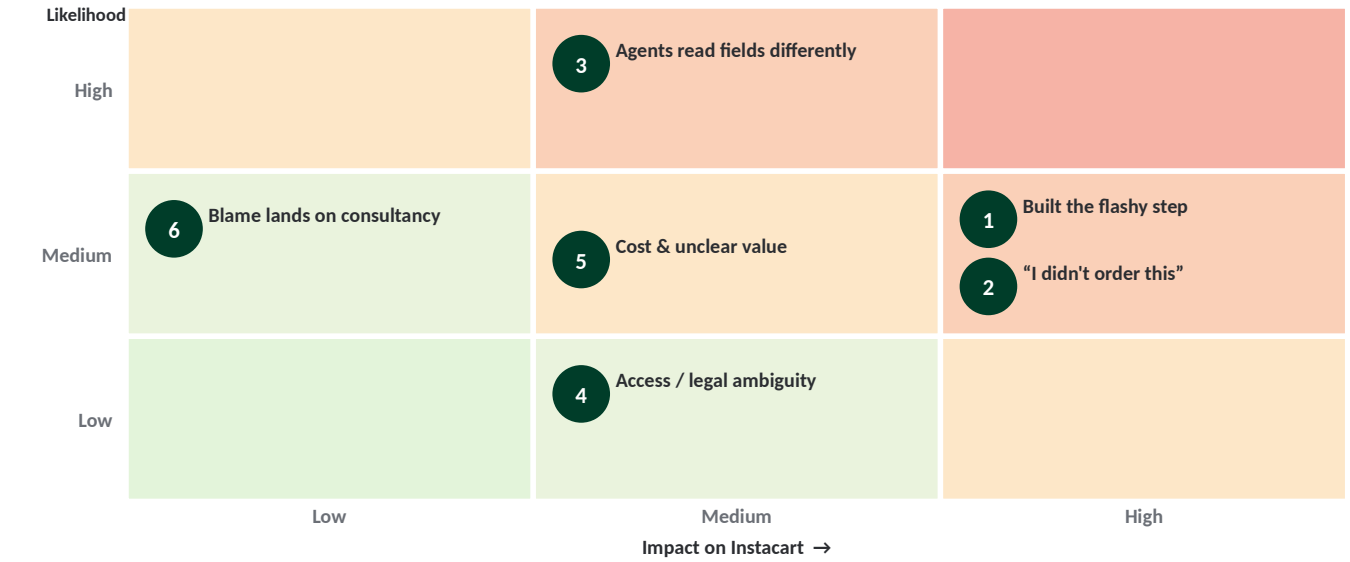
"Should we be worried? Will this happen to us?"

The question: A competitor's agent-readiness project stalls publicly at month 4 (bad press, client blaming its consultants). Instacart asks: "will this happen to us?" What do you say?

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"Yes, worried enough to act, not enough to stop." Their stall tells us the category is hard, not why theirs stopped. I show the failure modes, what we've designed out, what we don't know yet, and the tripwires we both sign.

Pre-mortem heat map: how projects like this fail (residual risk after our mitigations)



Failure mode	Public precedent	What we've already designed in
1 Built the flashy step	OpenAI/Walmart in-chat checkout, retired Mar '26 [11][12]	Substitution-first; tracer-bullet demo (Q2, Q3)
2 "I didn't order this"	Instacart's $60M FTC consent case; AI price tests halted, Dec '25 [14] [15]	Draft → hold → auto ladder; re-consent tap (Q5)
3 Fields read differently	Instacart itself deprecated bare quantity, Mar '26 [8]	Typed measures + read-back + shared corpus (Q4)
4 Access / legal	Amazon v. Perplexity: injunction Mar '26, vacated Aug '26 [16]	A sanctioned front door: MCP + OAuth scopes
5 Cost, unclear value	Gartner: >40% of agentic projects cancelled by 2027 [13]	4-week slices, each with a written "done"
6 Blame on consultancy	The competitor's own headline	Signed assumptions log + explicit decision rights

WHAT I SAY, VERBATIM

"Yes, you should take it seriously. A competitor stalling at month four tells us this is hard; it doesn't tell us why theirs stopped, and I won't guess about their project in front of you. What I can show you is how projects like this fail, which of those we've already designed out, what we still don't know, and three conditions under which we'd pause. If one trips, ***you hear it from me first, with the data****. Let's both sign them today."*

Our own uncertainty, stated plainly

WE KNOW

Order quality up **16 straight quarters** [5]; AI-assistant baskets beat the $115 AOV [5]; live in ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini [1–3]

WE DON'T KNOW

How often an agent order is unwanted (no history); appetite: **22%** trust agents to buy [19]; internal API gaps

WHEN WE WILL

Draft-rung edit data after **~4 weeks**; the 300-order bound for R1 around **week 12**

THREE TRIPWIRES, SIGNED IN WEEK 2

1. Agent issue ratio > human baseline + agreed margin → **freeze rung promotions**
2. "Didn't mean to order" rate > agreed rate → **that cohort back to Draft**
3. Any read-back mismatch that reaches a shopper → **release blocker**

FRAMEWORK **Pre-mortem + kill criteria + assumptions log**

What I won't do: speculate on their failure, distance us from the other firm, or promise zero incidents. Being honest about our own uncertainty is part of what we deliver.

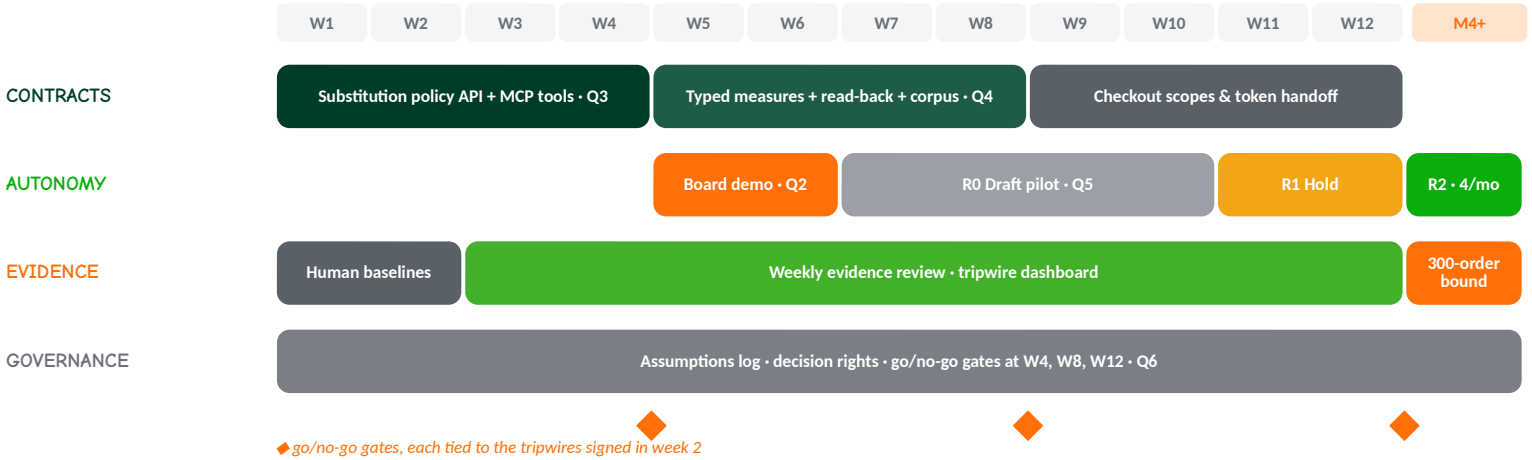
[1–3] ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini integrations · [5] Q2 2026 results · [8] Developer changelog · [11] Search Engine Land · [12] CNBC · [13] Gartner · [14] FTC, Dec 2025 · [15] Consumer Reports, Dec 2025 · [16] Cooley: Ninth Circuit, Aug 2026 · [19] FoodNavigator, Sep 2026

Putting it together: plan, scorecard, sources

How the six answers become one sequenced programme: each step produces the evidence the next one needs.

One contract, one ladder, one scorecard: substitution first, meaning second, autonomy last, with every step earning the evidence for the next.

12-week plan (2 engineers + product lead), then autonomy from month 4



Scorecard: judge success by clean orders, not autonomous GMV

Metric	Definition	Launch target / tripwire
★ **Clean agent orders**	North star: delivered with no edit, no issue, no "didn't mean to" tag	↑ share; ≥ human baseline
Unintended-order rate	"Didn't mean to order this" tags ÷ agent orders	tripwire > 0.5% (30-day)
Agent issue ratio	Orders with ≥1 issue (incl. poor replacement) ÷ agent orders	≤ human baseline
Policy coverage	Recurring-basket items with a readable substitution policy	100% of enrolled baskets
Read-back mismatch	Expected total ≠ resolved total	0 reaching a shopper
Draft edit rate	Share of lines edited per draft basket	< 10% to promote to R1

SOURCES

[1] Instacart: App launches in OpenAI ChatGPT, Instant Checkout (Dec 2025)
[2] Supermarket News: Instacart connects with Claude (24 Apr 2026)
[3] Instacart: Agentic grocery shopping comes to Gemini (19 May 2026)
[4] TechCrunch / PYMNTS: Instacart launches Clementine (9 Sep 2026)
[5] Instacart Q2 2026 results, prepared remarks & supplemental (6 Aug 2026)
[6] Instacart Q2 2026 earnings call: replacement model, 95% satisfaction
[7] Maplebear S-1 (2023) & Q3 2023 call: cohort frequency 2.1→3.9/mo
[8] Instacart Developer Platform changelog & create-shopping-list docs (18 Mar 2026)
[9] Instacart Docs: Connect your AI agent to Instacart with MCP
[10] Instacart Help Center: item & replacement instructions
[11] Search Engine Land: Walmart ChatGPT checkout converted 3× worse (Mar 2026)
[12] CNBC: OpenAI revamps ChatGPT shopping after Instant Checkout (24 Mar 2026)
[13] Gartner: >40% of agentic AI projects cancelled by 2027 (25 Jun 2025)
[14] FTC: Instacart to pay $60M in consumer refunds (Dec 2025)
[15] Consumer Reports: Instacart stops AI pricing tests (Dec 2025)
[16] Cooley: Ninth Circuit on AI-agent access, Amazon v. Perplexity (Aug 2026)
[17] Supermarket News: AI agents gaining the most trust with grocery shoppers (2026)
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[22] PYMNTS: Visa and Mastercard put tokens in charge of AI commerce (2026)
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[24] 9to5Google: Gemini Android app automation rollout (12 Mar 2026)
[25] PYMNTS: Anthropic's commerce agent blueprint (Sep 2026)

Evidence limits. Figures gathered from public sources, Sep 2026; cohort data is 2017–22 and marketplace-wide, not agent-specific. Survey figures vary by method. Every threshold here (4/mo, 0.5%, 5 eng-days, 300 orders, 100-listing corpus) is a **launch value to tune, not a finding**. Internal Instacart APIs were not visible to the author.

Plan dates are relative to engagement start. Q-tags show which answer each workstream implements.